Humayun’s new-found domestic bliss was charming no doubt, but it was hardly calculated to overawe an enemy. Seeing Humayun so disinclined to march upon Thatta, Shah Husain brought his own army to the slack conqueror. Camped a few miles from Jun, the shah began to send skirmishing parties against Humayun’s soldiers, and secret overtures to his commanders. Rana Prasad, meanwhile, had quarrelled with one of these Chagatai chiefs – and was tiring of the endless wait. He left in a huff, exclaiming, as Jouher reports, that ‘any attempt to assist the Moghuls was a loss of labour and time’.[3]

With the rana went his men, at which the smaller chieftains of Sindh, who had allied with Rana Prasad and Humayun, abandoned the campaign, too, leaving Humayun ‘alone, as before, with his own people’.[4] These people were not immune to temptation, as Humayun knew too well; one by one his commanders began to desert. Among them was that would-be turncoat Munim Khan – this time, Humayun was not alert enough to prevent his leaving.

Humayun’s time in Jun was running out as fast as his men, but before it ended altogether, there was one man who joined him in his riverside garden; one man who was worth more than all the others put together in what he would do, not just for this emperor without a throne, but for his dynasty.

Abul Fazl gives Bairam Khan the hero’s entrance he deserves. It was the spring of 1543, and Shah Husain’s attacks were unceasing. There was one ongoing, in fact, as Bairam rode into view. Without pause, the soldier charged into the heart of the battle, as if from ‘the secret army [of God]’. Humayun’s men let out shouts of delight when they recognized him.

They would have met last at the rout in Kannauj. Bairam had joined Babur’s service when he was sixteen,[5] and while he couldn’t prevent Babur’s heir’s unseemly rout from Hindustan, the soldier had acquired a reputation for military prowess. So much so, in fact, that not one but two Hindustani rulers tried to poach him before he managed to rejoin Humayun’s camp: Sher Shah the Afghan and Sultan Mahmud of Gujarat. Bairam refused Sher Shah’s offer (‘whoever keeps his loyalty, shall not stumble,’ he said with flair) and barely escaped the aggrieved shah’s domain with his life.[6] When Bairam arrived in Gujarat, he had learnt not to offend kings; he did not refuse Sultan Mahmud’s offer of employment, only asked